

Operational Gap Assessment

Scaling Deerfield Intelligence from 10 to 30 people

Executive diagnosis

Deerfield Intelligence (DI) needs a lightweight operating backbone to support threefold growth without sacrificing the speed and entrepreneurialism that make the team effective. The current model works because a small group of leaders holds priorities, dependencies, stakeholder context and operating decisions in their heads. That approach is already creating avoidable delays and will become unreliable as demand and headcount grow.

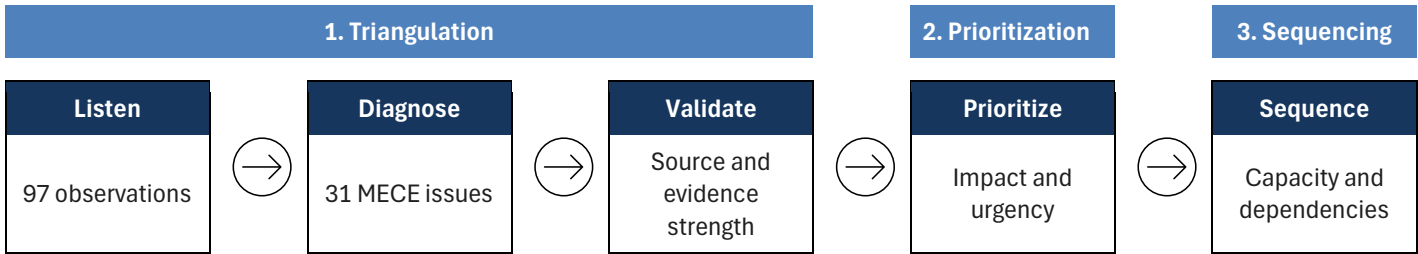
What the evidence shows

Gap family	Current state	Scaling implication	Priority
Portfolio control and delivery reliability	Demand enters through informal channels; status, capacity and dependencies are not visible in one place.	Commitments become harder to defend as work and specialization increase.	Priority 1
Hiring and onboarding readiness	Recruiting depends on sequential coordination; new-hire setup lacks one owner and a standard path.	DI cannot absorb approximately 20 hires efficiently if candidates and new employees wait for decisions or access.	Priority 1
Cross-boundary operating ownership	Workflows spanning pods and corporate functions rely on relationships, translation and escalation to senior leaders.	David and pod leads become bottlenecks as transaction volume grows.	Priority 2
Vendor and spend controls	Supplier records, renewals, cloud variance and approval steps are fragmented or detected late.	Cost leakage, rework and control exposure rise with technology consumption.	Priority 2
Technical and governance maturity	Product ownership, shared platforms, model governance, documentation, and evidence of data or access controls are incomplete.	Risk and maintenance burden accumulate, but most full builds should follow the first 90 days.	Priority 3 (and selected P2)

The immediate requirement is not more process. It is a small set of operating mechanisms that makes demand, commitments, dependencies and ownership visible while standardizing only the workflows where delay or risk is material.

How the gaps were diagnosed

Interview triangulation was used to separate operating gaps from symptoms and individual pain points



Worked example

Stage	Application
What was heard (Listen)	Project status lives in memory, Slack and partial documents. Cross-pod capacity is sometimes committed before the supplying pod agrees. Leaders must ask individuals for the current version of priorities and status.
Underlying diagnosis (Diagnose)	DI lacks a shared portfolio view and a forward-looking decision rhythm. Late dependencies and unreliable commitments are consequences of that missing mechanism.
How it was validated (Validate)	The pattern appeared across Marcus, Priya and David, with concrete delivery examples and direct acknowledgement that the current model will not scale.
Classification (Prioritize & Sequence)	High-confidence systemic issue. Portfolio intake, visibility, capacity and dependency management advance to P1 because they constrain multiple downstream workflows.

Classification rules

Type	Meaning	Treatment
Systemic	Recurrs across teams or workflows and is likely to worsen materially at 30 people.	Advance when material
Localized	Material but bounded to one workflow, function or risk domain.	Prioritize on impact
Perception	A credible concern without enough independent evidence to confirm the operating gap.	Validate before scaling
Symptom	An observed consequence such as meeting load, escalation or leadership time.	Address through root cause

Only validated systemic gaps and material localized gaps advance to prioritization. Frequency of mention informs confidence, but does not determine priority; a single well-evidenced regulatory exposure may matter more than a commonly mentioned inconvenience.

1. Triangulation and Gap assessment

Five gap families account for most operational friction and scaling risk

Gap family	Included issues	Diagnosis	Risk at 30	Priority
Portfolio and delivery management	PIP-01, PMO-01, XPD-01, CAP-01, SCP-01, PCE-01	Demand, commitments, capacity and dependencies are managed through informal channels rather than one portfolio mechanism.	High	P1 and P2
Talent scaling	WFP-01, HIR-01, ONB-01, ONB-02	Workforce sequencing, recruiting execution and employee ramp are not designed for sustained hiring volume.	High	P1 and P2
Cross-functional execution	ORG-01, CORP-01, CORP-02, CORP-03	No consistent operating ownership joins DI context with specialist approval and service responsibilities.	High	P2
Financial and vendor management	VEN-01, FIN-01, FIN-02, BVC-01	Forecasting, commitments, renewals and cost-to-outcome visibility are fragmented.	High to medium	P2 and P3
Technical lifecycle and controls	PLC-01, PLT-01, PCE-02, MDL-01, IAM-01, DPG-01	Ownership and control evidence are incomplete across deployed products, shared foundations, models, access and sensitive data.	Medium	P2 and P3

What is deliberately not elevated

Issue area	Assessment
Leadership and meeting burden	A symptom of weak visibility, unresolved decision rights and ad hoc coordination. It should improve as the underlying mechanisms change.
Generic HR, Finance or central-function interfaces	These labels were too broad and overlapped with specific workflows. Evidence was reassigned to recruiting, onboarding, financial planning, vendor approvals and operating decision rights.
Firm-wide talent policies	Career paths, titles and pay bands, office expectations, performance documentation and exceptional retention processes remain important but require broader firm sponsorship and relationship capital.
Broader investment-organization integration	The evidence is currently limited and the solution is unclear. Validate directly with Investment Partners before adding a meeting or communications layer.

The full register contains 31 non-overlapping issue statements. The families above are presentation groupings, not additional issues.

2. Prioritization

Six critical issues span two important operating agendas: (i) portfolio control and delivery reliability and (ii) hiring and new hire productivity

Priority reflects business impact, urgency, scale dependency and implementation effort. The numerical score remains in the working file; the assessment uses four judgment-based bands to avoid false precision.

Band	Issues	Meaning
P1 Critical	6	Immediate constraints and foundational enablers
P2 High	14	Material gaps to address selectively or begin within the first 90 days
P3 Medium	5	Important next-wave capabilities after the operating foundation is stable
P4 Longer-term	6	Important but dependent on evidence, policy sponsorship or broader firm change

P1 agenda one Portfolio control and delivery reliability

- Controlled intake and prioritization across investment, portfolio-company and internal demand
- One source of truth and a forward-looking operating rhythm for the portfolio
- Earlier acceptance of cross-pod dependencies before external dates are promised
- A lightweight workload view that makes capacity and displacement visible

P1 agenda two Hiring and new-hire productivity

- A faster recruiting process with committed panels, feedback timing and delegated decisions
- One owner and a repeatable setup path for day-one technical access

Why these issues lead

Together, the P1 issues determine whether DI can make credible commitments and absorb growth. They also have leverage: resolving them should reduce reactive coordination, senior-leader escalation, duplicated effort and idle time without creating a large new process layer.

3. Sequencing

The first 90 days should establish control without turning 31 issues into 31 projects

The plan assumes one Director of Operations who owns orchestration, not every specialist decision or deliverable. Work is grouped into integrated workstreams, and no more than three substantial builds should be active at once.

Timing	Workstream	Scope	Ownership model
0 to 30 days	Portfolio control minimum viable system	Single intake; initiative inventory; common status fields; weekly decision forum; capacity bands; cross-pod dependency acceptance	Director of Operations with David and pod leads
0 to 30 days	Hiring and onboarding readiness	Requisition-readiness gate; reserved interview panels; feedback targets; day-one access checklist; first-30-day plan	Director of Operations with HR, IT and hiring managers
0 to 30 days	Immediate spend safeguards	Vendor inventory and renewal calendar; cloud-cost visibility and anomaly escalation	Finance and technical owners, orchestrated by Operations
31 to 60 days	Operating ownership and project initiation	Decision-rights map; project charter; portfolio-company handoff; sequenced workforce plan	Operations with David, pod leads, HR and sponsors
61 to 90 days	Core corporate workflows	Vendor fast path; Legal and Compliance triggers; ongoing access request path; monthly financial pulse	Specialist functions retain approval authority
Post 90 days	Control and capability builds	Portfolio deployment liability; access evidence; sensitive-data governance; model lifecycle; product and platform ownership; talent architecture	Sequenced with Legal, Compliance, IT, Finance and HR

Sequencing guardrails

- Use interim controls and risk triage for deferred P2 issues; do not presume full policy or technology implementation within 90 days.
- Require functional owners to supply specialist judgment and execution capacity. Operations designs the interface, tracks decisions and escalates exceptions.
- Delay new tooling until the team has defined the minimum information, ownership and cadence the tool must support.

Sequencing principle

Capture immediate value through lightweight mechanisms while using the first 90 days to establish the foundations for longer-term operating-model and control changes.

Supporting material

Appendix A: Full issue register

ID	Priority	Issue statement	Signal	Timing
PIP-01	P1 Critical	DI lacks a controlled intake and prioritization process across investment, portfolio-company and internal demand.	Strong signal	0–30 days
PMO-01	P1 Critical	DI lacks a shared source of truth and forward-looking operating rhythm for its portfolio of work.	Emerging signal	0–30 days
XPD-01	P1 Critical	Cross-pod dependencies are surfaced and committed too late, making delivery dates unreliable.	Emerging signal	0–30 days
CAP-01	P1 Critical	Capacity and delivery commitments are based on judgment rather than a visible workload view.	Weak signal	0–30 days
SCP-01	P2 High	Accepted projects can begin without clear scope, stakeholder obligations or a definition of done.	Emerging signal	31–60 days
PCE-01	P2 High	Portfolio-company engagements begin without a standardized handoff or clear counterpart responsibilities.	Weak signal	31–60 days
PCE-02	P2 High	Regulatory responsibility and liability are unclear when DI deploys technology to portfolio companies.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
PLC-01	P3 Medium	Post-launch ownership, support expectations and critical product knowledge are not consistently maintained.	Emerging signal	Post-90 days
PLT-01	P3 Medium	Ownership and standards for shared infrastructure, DevOps and cross-pod data foundations are unclear.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
ORG-01	P2 High	Recurring cross-boundary workflows lack explicit process owners, decision rights and escalation paths.	Strong signal	31–60 days
CORP-01	P2 High	Vendor and data-source onboarding lacks a fast, controlled end-to-end approval path.	Strong signal	31–60 days
CORP-02	P2 High	Projects, deployments and new data uses reach Legal and Compliance late and follow an opaque, overly bespoke review path.	Emerging signal	61–90 days
CORP-03	P2 High	Ongoing security and data-access requests lack predictable routing, context and turnaround.	Emerging signal	61–90 days
VEN-01	P2 High	DI lacks a complete vendor inventory, accountable owners and disciplined renewal management.	Emerging signal	0–30 days
FIN-01	P2 High	DI lacks a regular, driver-based financial planning process connecting roadmap, hiring, vendors and technology use to spend.	Emerging signal	61–90 days
FIN-02	P2 High	Cloud spend is monitored too late to prevent material budget variance.	Emerging signal	0–30 days
BVC-01	P3 Medium	DI lacks full business-case visibility connecting material project spend to the outcomes created.	Emerging signal	Post-90 days
WFP-01	P2 High	DI lacks a clear, sequenced workforce plan for growth from 10 to 30.	Weak signal	31–60 days
WFP-02	P3 Medium	DI has not resolved how leadership structure and management capacity should evolve as the team grows.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
WFP-03	P4 Longer-term	Levels and career paths are not defined for DI technical talent.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
WFP-04	P4 Longer-term	Firm-wide titles and pay bands do not map cleanly to DI's technical roles.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
HIR-01	P1 Critical	The recruiting process is too slow and dependent on ad hoc coordination to support planned hiring volume.	Emerging signal	0–30 days
HIR-02	P4 Longer-term	Firm-wide office expectations may constrain access to specialized AI talent.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
ONB-01	P1 Critical	New-hire technical onboarding lacks an end-to-end owner, day-one access and a standard setup path.	Strong signal	0–30 days
ONB-02	P2 High	New hires lack a structured first-30-day plan and integration into the broader firm.	Weak signal	0–30 days
ORG-02	P4 Longer-term	Performance management is informal and insufficiently documented.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
ORG-03	P4 Longer-term	Annual compensation cycles do not provide a clear response path for time-sensitive retention risks.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
MDL-01	P3 Medium	DI lacks a formal inventory and governance lifecycle for AI models used in investment activity.	Weak signal	Post-90 days
IAM-01	P2 High	Access controls and information barriers are not documented or evidenced at the required level.	Emerging signal	Post-90 days
DPG-01	P2 High	DI lacks an explicit governance framework for sensitive data and outbound third-party data use.	Emerging signal	Post-90 days
INT-01	P4 Longer-term	DI is insufficiently integrated with the broader investment organization, weakening shared context and support for resources.	Weak signal	Post-90 days

Note: “Signal” is implied from the number of unique sources and mention count within those interviews.

Evidence and prioritization

Appendix B: Evidence base scoring and assumptions

Evidence base

The assessment draws on 97 structured observations from 6 stakeholders. Repeated descriptions of the same event were treated as corroboration of the mechanism, not as separate incidents.

Stakeholder	Observations
Elena Rodriguez	18
James Okonkwo	16
Marcus Thompson	18
Priya Sharma	18
Sarah	15
David Chen	12

Prioritization criteria

Each issue was rated on a scale of 1 to 5 for each criterion, generating a priority score to support prioritization.

Criterion	Question tested
Business impact	Effect on DI delivery, controls, talent, cost or stakeholder confidence
Urgency	Whether delay creates immediate or compounding exposure
Scale dependency	Likelihood the current approach breaks as DI grows from 10 to 30
Effort	Time, complexity, specialist dependency and broader-policy involvement

Key assumptions and limitations

- The interviews are directional and do not replace validation against recruiting, budget, vendor, cloud, access and project artifacts.
- Single-source issues can still be material, particularly in regulated domains, but confidence remains lower until documentation or additional stakeholders confirm the gap.
- The sequence assumes the Director of Operations can secure time from pod leaders and named corporate-function counterparts.
- Post-90-day timing means full implementation is deferred. Material risks should still receive triage, an accountable owner and an interim control during the first 90 days.
- The detailed evidence log, scoring calculations, and issue-to-observation mapping remain in the **Operational Gap Assessment Tool** (see <https://github.com/jmcgibbon/deerfield-intelligence-operations/tree/main/04-Supporting-Materials> to access tool).